Leave and Time Off Policy

Internal draft - approval required before employee use

Effective date: Pending approval

Policy owner: People Operations

1. Purpose and Scope

This policy explains paid time off, sick leave, holidays, parental leave, bereavement, jury duty, and the process for requesting time away. Northstar Labs will administer legally protected leave according to applicable law, even when that law provides rights beyond this policy.

2. Paid Time Off

Regular full-time employees receive 20 paid time off days per calendar year. New-hire and final-year allocations are prorated by full calendar month. Regular part-time employees receive a prorated allocation based on scheduled hours. Temporary workers and independent contractors do not receive paid time off under this policy.

Employees should request planned paid time off in the leave system as early as practical and normally at least 10 calendar days before an absence of three or more consecutive workdays. Managers consider team coverage, customer commitments, and equitable access when approving dates.

Approval must be recorded before an employee treats planned time as approved. Northstar Labs may limit carryover to five unused days into the next calendar year. Carried days must be used by March 31 unless applicable law requires otherwise.

3. Sick Leave

Regular full-time employees receive 10 paid sick days per calendar year. Sick leave may be used for the employee's illness, injury, preventive care, or qualifying care of a family member. Part-time sick leave is provided according to applicable law and any company allocation shown in the leave system.

When illness is unexpected, employees should notify their manager before their scheduled start time when practical and record the absence in the leave system as soon as they are able. People Operations may request permitted documentation for an extended or recurring absence.

4. Paid Company Holidays

Northstar Labs observes 11 paid company holidays each calendar year. The annual holiday calendar is published before the start of the year. When operational coverage is required on a holiday, the manager will arrange an alternate paid day off consistent with applicable law.

5. Paid Parental Leave

An eligible employee receives up to 12 weeks of paid parental leave for birth, adoption, or placement of a child. Eligibility requires 12 completed months of employment as of the leave start date. Leave should normally be requested at least 30 calendar days in advance when the need is foreseeable.

Parental leave may be taken in one continuous period. An intermittent schedule requires advance written approval from People Operations and the employee's manager. Paid parental leave runs concurrently with any applicable legally protected family leave to the extent permitted by law.

During approved paid parental leave, active benefits continue on the terms stated in the Benefits Guide, provided the employee continues required employee contributions. People Operations will explain any coordination with disability benefits or legally required leave.

6. Bereavement Leave

Regular employees may take up to five paid workdays following the death of an immediate family member and up to two paid workdays for another close relationship. People Operations may approve additional paid time off or unpaid leave based on circumstances and applicable law.

7. Jury and Witness Duty

Northstar Labs provides paid time for required jury service and legally compelled witness service, less any offset required by applicable law. Employees should provide the summons to People Operations promptly and remain available for work when released for a substantial part of a scheduled day, when practical.

8. Request and Approval Process

1. Submit the request in the leave system with the leave type, dates, and expected return date.
2. Notify the manager directly when timing is urgent or unforeseeable.
3. Provide documentation only through the secure channel identified by People Operations.
4. Wait for recorded approval for planned leave; emergency and protected-leave rules may apply differently.
5. Notify the manager and People Operations if dates change.

A manager's approval of scheduling does not decide whether an absence qualifies for protected leave or benefits. People Operations makes eligibility determinations and provides required notices.

9. Unplanned and Ambiguous Requests

An employee asking to take time off "tomorrow" must identify the reason or leave category, available balance where relevant, and whether the need is urgent. Planned paid time off requires manager approval. An unexpected illness should follow the sick-leave notification process. A request that may involve protected leave should be referred to People Operations rather than denied solely for short notice.

10. No Retaliation

Northstar Labs prohibits retaliation for requesting or using leave in good faith, raising a concern about leave administration, or participating in a review. Suspected retaliation may be reported through the channels in the Code of Conduct and Reporting Policy.